Army cadet, at the IMA, Dehradun as part of the 5th Course, even participating in the inaugural parade of the Joint Services Wing, Clement Town, Dehradun, which later became the NDA. Unfortunately, while playing football one evening, he broke his knee and had to leave on medical grounds, as he was permanently downgraded to 'unfit for military service'. It was only after that, on completion of his graduation, that he joined the Air Force. But in his heart of hearts, he was an Army man and an Infantryman to boot, and that was to affect my decisions in later years.

The arrival of the call letter set in train a whole set of activities. By then, my brother Nitin had also come to Pune and was pursuing a degree at the Brihan Maharashtra College of Commerce (BMCC). My mother and he decided that I was too skinny (I must have been about 45 kg or so) and needed to be fattened up, like the proverbial sacrificial lamb, although I had passed my medical exam, with the medical officer declaring it was better to be underweight than overweight. So, one morning, a sumptuous continental breakfast was laid out, not unlike what I would later have at the Academy. Juice, porridge, eggs with fries on the side, toast with butter and jam, topped up with malted milk. I dutifully consumed the entire spread and then going to the washroom, brought it all out in the bathroom sink. That was the first and last attempt to 'fatten' me. Then there was the question of obtaining a reservation on a train to Madras. After consulting the Bradshaw, I went to the Pune Railway Station and bought a second-class sleeper ticket for a grand sum of Rs 50. I was fearful of pickpockets and not wanting to lose the ticket, instead of keeping it in my wallet, kept it somewhere else. On returning home, I just couldn't find the ticket and could not fathom how and when it must have fallen out and got lost. It was most embarrassing, to say the

Copyright © Penguin Random House India
Not for circulation